inspirational figure for the yatris, not the least because of the intensity and consistency of his commitment to the Yatra. Like many of the yatris, he had to overcome his own physical challenges and keep moving despite physical injury. But unlike the other yatris, he had to shoulder the weight of the expectations, which surely had to feel unbearable at times.

For example, take a look at Rahul Gandhi's schedule. Apart from walking 20 to 30 kilometres every day, in the first hundred days of the Yatra, he headlined ninety-four corner meetings (one almost every day), eight press conferences and eight public meetings or large rallies of more than a lakh people. Almost every day he had closed-door meetings with diverse groups, all clamouring for his time. He set a relentless pace, across the unforgiving hours, days and months of the Bharat Jodo Yatra.

For all we know, the Rahul Gandhi who went on the Yatra may have been exactly the same man who completed it. But to those who walked the Yatra with him, he seemed changed, perhaps even transformed into a figure of greater gravitas and a greater presence. Or perhaps it was merely our perception of him that had changed over time.

The question asked at the outset, even among Congress-party leaders, was whether he would be able to walk 20 to 30 kilometres day after day. Did he have it in him? The answer was a resounding yes.

In my opinion, Rahul Gandhi's gruelling schedule helped redefine his leadership. For those who observed him in closed-door interactions with tribal communities, farmers and intellectuals, the breadth of his vision and the fluency of his communication were revelatory. This wasn't the 'Pappu' portrayed in social media—this was a leader with vision and gravitas. From the crucible of the Bharat Jodo Yatra emerged a different Rahul Gandhi, one who was earlier shrouded in the miasma of misinformation from alternate narratives and fake-news factories.

What Was It All for?